

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

NASCAR puts pause on street race



People along Michigan Avenue catch a glimpse of the NASCAR Chicago Street Race through barriers on July 6. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Organization pulls out of Chicago for next year while exploring new date and shorter build-out

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

Two weeks after its third annual Fourth of July weekend run through Grant Park, NASCAR has made the decision not to hold the Chicago Street Race in 2026, leaving open the door to return on a different date the following year.

In a letter Friday to Mayor Brandon Johnson, NASCAR said

it is pausing the race because it needs more time to explore rescheduling the event and ways to speed up the build-out and breakdown of the pop-up racecourse in response to concerns from the city.

“Our goal is for the Chicago Street Race to return in 2027 with an event that further enhances the experience for residents and visitors alike, as we work together

towards a new potential date, shorter build schedule, and additional tourism draws,” Julie Giese, NASCAR Chicago Street Race president, said in the letter.

Giese said the NASCAR Chicago office will remain open and “work collaboratively” with the city to reschedule the street race, further optimize “operational efficiencies” on the build-out and potentially find ways to enhance the event’s appeal as a tourism draw.

NASCAR also pledges to remain

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“I hope parties return to the table with a commitment to making this event work even better for Chicago, both logistically and financially.”

— Ald. Bill Conway, whose 34th Ward intersects the temporary racecourse, in a statement

ELECTION 2026

Slating a blow to Stratton, Pritzker

County Dems mum on Senate race, snub incumbent assessor

By Rick Pearson and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

In a blow to Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker and a reflection of divided allegiances, the Cook County Democratic Party failed Friday to endorse Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton for retiring U.S. Sen. Dick Durbin’s seat and instead backed an open primary with U.S. Reps. Raja Krishnamoorthi and Robin Kelly.

Holding their quadrennial slating session for state and county offices, county Democratic slatemakers also snubbed Cook County Assessor Fritz Kaegi and instead endorsed, by an overwhelming margin, Lyons Township Assessor Patrick Hynes for the countywide job.

The party also endorsed state Rep. Margaret Croke of Chicago by a tissue-paper-thin margin for the state comptroller’s spot being vacated by incumbent Susana Mendoza, who is not seeking reelection and is expected to make a 2027 bid for Chicago mayor.

In the Senate race, the slating session was intended to mark the first time the three major Democrats vying for the party nomination to succeed Durbin would come together in a high-profile public forum to make their case for the county party’s backing.

But Kelly missed her flight from Washington, D.C., after a late round of votes that concluded early Friday morning on the Trump recession package, which cuts funding for foreign aid and public

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Always Moore to learn

Chicago Bears receiver DJ Moore builds a water-propelled rocket with Diego, 11, left, and Josiah, 11, right, at a Back-to-School Bash at the Bartlett J. McCartin Boys & Girls Club on Friday. The club teamed up with the receiver’s Moore2Life Foundation to host the event for youths.

Zoning chair pick again fraught with politics

Johnson seeks someone who reflects his values as Black, Latino caucuses jockey for coveted role

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

As the departure of Ald. Walter Burnett leaves Mayor Brandon Johnson with the challenge of picking his third Zoning Committee chair, the City Council’s Black and Latino caucuses have already begun jockeying for the highly coveted leadership spot.

Burnett, often dubbed the “dean” of the council as its most tenured member, will step down at the end of July, vacating both his committee chairmanship and role as Johnson’s vice mayor. The Zoning appointment has been one of the freshman mayor’s biggest political conundrums throughout the first two years of his term, and his next choice is expected to

make waves in a council where racial politics remain an undercurrent.

To that end, the heads of both the Black and Latino caucuses are calling for the chairmanship to go to one of their members. And Vice Chair Ald. Bennett Lawson, who is white, has expressed interest in the permanent role too.

Johnson, for his part, would not say Wednesday where his inclinations lie.

“The most important thing here is that we have someone

who ... reflects my values,” he told reporters when asked if the Black Caucus should retain the Zoning chair spot. “We’ll go through a process, like we’ve always gone through, and the person that best reflects our ability to build the safest, most affordable big city in America ... I feel very confident that we’ll find the right person.”

Latino Caucus Chair Ald. Andre Vasquez confirmed Thursday he is interested in seeking the

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MONTANO TRIAL

Alleged cop killer says he feared for his life

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

With fear and energy surging through his body, Steven Montano heard a voice screaming at him to stop and saw a gun pointed at him. So, he said, he fired his own gun.

That was how Montano, 21, described to the jury Friday the fateful moment during which he fatally shot Chicago police Officer Andrés Vázquez Lasso during a confrontation in which Montano himself was shot.

Montano is charged with first-degree murder and other felonies in the slaying of the

32-year-old officer on March 1, 2023, but he has argued that he shot the officer in self-defense in a moment of extreme stress and fear.

To support the claim, Montano, in a gray striped suit, took the stand at the Leighton Criminal Court Building and told his side of a story that has unfolded throughout the week.

“I was terrified,” Montano said. “I was in fear of my life.”

While children played on a nearby playground just before 5 p.m., Montano shot Vázquez Lasso five times after officers responded to a domestic-related 911 call phoned in by Monta-

no’s girlfriend, prosecutors have said. Vázquez Lasso also shot and wounded Montano.

Cook County prosecutors rested their case earlier Friday after putting on more than a dozen witnesses and airing body camera footage throughout the week that depicted the shooting and its aftermath. The jury, which was empaneled Monday, previously heard from emotional police officers who tried to revive Vázquez Lasso before rushing him to the hospital as well as his wife, who recalled saying goodbye to her husband one last time

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UChicago to end youth gender care

Bowing to federal pressure under the Trump administration, UChicago Medicine has become the latest Illinois hospital to end gender-affirming pediatric care, leaving numerous patients in limbo. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Epstein grand jury files requested

President Donald Trump announced Thursday that he was seeking the release of testimony from the prosecution of Jeffrey Epstein, and Friday, the administration asked a court to unseal transcripts. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER High 83 Low 69

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\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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